A Former Teacher Wins a Big Senate Race in Texas

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Democrat James Talarico has won a **Senate** race in Texas. He is the first Democrat to win a **Senate** seat in the state since 1988.

Talarico used to be a schoolteacher. He beat Republican Ken Paxton, and his win helped Democrats take control of Congress.

Many people did not know Talarico's name last year. In his **campaign**, he talked a lot about how expensive everyday life has become. Paxton said Talarico's ideas were too **progressive** for Texas.

The race was the most expensive **Senate** race in history. More than half a billion dollars was spent. **Billionaire** Elon Musk gave $158 million to a group that supported Paxton.

At a party in Austin, Talarico told his supporters, "We just proved that all the money in the world is no match for the people of Texas."

Texas is the second most populous state in the country, and Democrats had not won a race like this there for decades.

Word Treasure

campaign -- The work a person does to try to win an election, like giving speeches and meeting voters.

progressive -- Wanting big changes and new ideas in how a country is run.

billionaire -- A person who has more than a billion dollars.

Senate -- One of the two parts of Congress; each state elects two senators.

Background you need

A senator helps make laws for the whole country in Congress.

Texas is a very big state where Democrats had not won a race like this for a long time.

Winning there was a huge surprise.

Break it down

WHO: James Talarico, a former schoolteacher, and his supporters
WHAT: He won a U.S. Senate race in Texas, the first Democrat to do so since 1988
WHERE: In Texas, with a celebration in Austin
WHY: He talked about the rising cost of everyday life, and voters chose him over Ken Paxton

Why it matters

The race shows that even a contest with record spending can be won by an ordinary person like a teacher -- someone kids see every day.

Test what you remember

1. Who won the Senate race in Texas?

- (A) James Talarico
- (B) Greg Abbott
- (C) Ken Paxton
- (D) Elon Musk

2. What was Talarico's job before?

- (A) Billionaire
- (B) Singer
- (C) Farmer
- (D) Schoolteacher

3. When was the last time a Democrat won a Senate seat in Texas before this?

- (A) 2000
- (B) Never
- (C) 1988
- (D) 2020

4. How much money was spent on the race?

- (A) More than half a billion dollars
- (B) One million dollars
- (C) One hundred dollars
- (D) No money at all

5. What did Talarico talk about a lot in his campaign?

- (A) Space travel
- (B) Movie stars
- (C) How expensive everyday life has become
- (D) Football

6. Where did Talarico speak to his supporters?

- (A) London
- (B) Austin
- (C) Los Angeles
- (D) New York

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: D 3: C 4: A 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

1. James Talarico: Told supporters that all the money in the world is no match for the people of Texas.

2. Ken Paxton: Said Talarico's ideas were too progressive for Texas.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):